

Q1: The Rise of Populist Voting: Case Study of the French 2024 Election.

If populist voting is routinely expounded as a reaction to economic decline, this is less than an empirical consensus, but rather an analytical shortcut. Such interpretations privilege material grievances as the primary driver for electoral change; on the other hand, this begs the question of accountability towards the struggle for why similar economic conditions can produce divergent political outcomes across voters and contexts. Reassemblement National's (RN) electoral success in 2024 in France spotlights this tension of sharp relief. While frequently characterised as an expression of economic discontent or protest against incumbents, the RN's support is better understood as emerging from the intersection of economic insecurity, cultural conflict, and the erosion of political trust, whereby dynamics cannot be simply reduced to a single explanatory dimension. RN does not merely benefit from these conditions, but actively structures them.

As a populist radical right party, it reframes political competition around a moralised opposition between "the people" and a delegitimised elite, embedding this antagonism within exclusionary narratives of national identity.¹ Accordingly, by transforming diffuse grievances into politically coherent choices, we are able to see this in RN's ownership of issues such as immigration and sovereignty. Further pinpointing that populist voting is beyond just reactive, but is mediated through party strategy, issue salience, and the broader configuration of political competition.² This paper will argue that the rise of the RN voting in 2024 is best explained as the product of interacting mechanisms across competing theories of voting behaviour. Economic voting literature generates conditions of dissatisfaction, however it is through issue voting and the psychological process of identity formation that these conditions are politically activated. Enabled by long-term dealignment, traditional partisan loyalties become weaker and in return, increases electoral volatility.³ Through synthesising sociological, psychological and rational choice approaches, this paper eclipses monocausal explanations to demonstrate that RN's success reflects a deeper reorganisation of electoral behavior and the structure of democratic explanation.

Economic Voting Reconsidered

¹ Mudde, C. (2004), *The Populist Zeitgeist*, Government and Opposition , 39(4), pg.541-563

² Ivarsflaten, E. (2008), What Unites Right-Wing Populists in Western Europe?, Comparative Political Studies, 41(4), pg.2-23

³ Dalton, R. (2018), Political Realignment; Kriesi et al(2008), West European Politics in the Age of Globalisation

At first glance, interpreting the rise of support for the RN primarily as a consequence of economic decline is theoretically persuasive.⁴ France had entered the 2024 electoral cycle amidst inflationary pressures, anxieties surrounding purchasing power and societal deadlock, whereby conditions appear highly compatible with retrospective models of economic voting associated with Fiorina(1981).⁵ In such scenarios, voters are then expected to sanction incumbent actors when economic performance deteriorates; rewarding or punishing governments in accordance to perceived material outcomes, allowing the RN's electoral breakthrough to be plausibly situated within a wider climate of anti-incumbent dissatisfaction. While economic voting offers an intuitively compelling explanation for electoral volatility, its explanatory reach becomes considerably weaker once the political direction of that volatility is interrogated much more closely.

The heart of the matter is not about the presence of economic dissatisfaction, but why such dissatisfaction becomes articulated specifically through a populist radical right formation. Shown in Figure 2, grievances with the economy are not uniquely concentrated amongst right-wing respondents, however are broadly distributed across the electorate.

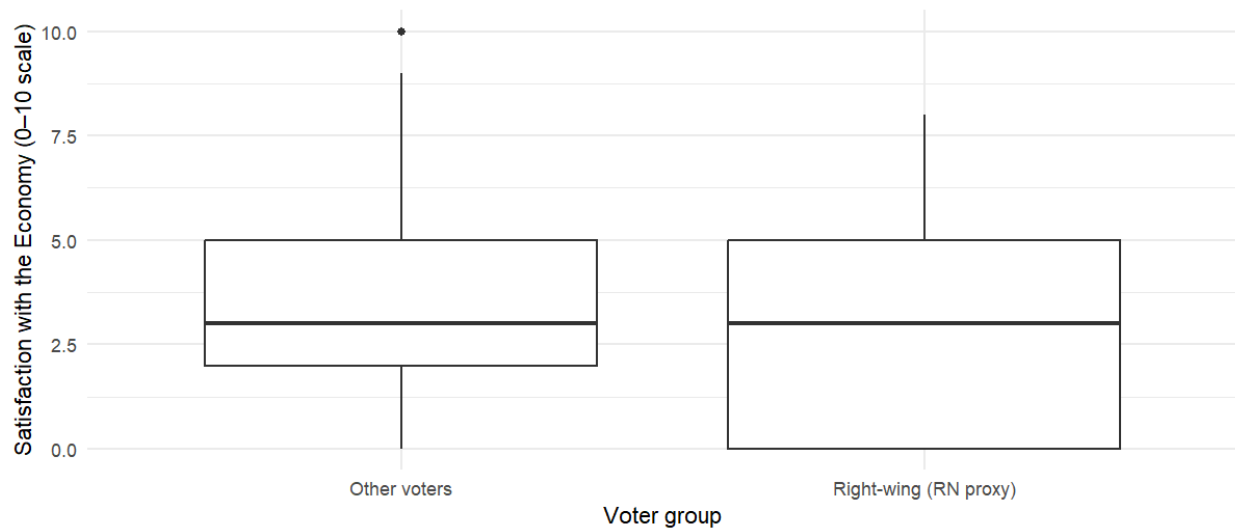
The substantial overlap presented between both groups rectifies any straightforward interpretation of RN support as the automatic political expression of material grievance. If economic insecurity alone were to be sufficient enough to produce populist radical right voting, it would be predictable to expect far clearer differentiation between RN-aligned voters and the remainder of the electorate. The evidence shown in Figure 2 suggests otherwise, curating economic malaise to possess no inherent ideological direction. Material insecurity may generate frustration with incumbent institutions, however itself does not dictate whether or not voters turn towards the populist right, redistributionist left parties or political disengagement altogether.

Figure 2: Economic Dissatisfaction is More Weakly Structured by Right-Wing Alignment(France)

⁴ Record inflation hot topic ahead of French legislative elections | Euractiv
<https://www.euractiv.com/news/record-inflation-becomes-hot-topic-ahead-of-french-elections/> Accessed: (08/05/26)

⁵ Fiorina, M., (1981), *Retrospective Voting in American National Elections*. New Haven: Yale University Press.

Figure 2: Economic Dissatisfaction Is More Weakly Structured by Right-Wing Alignment (France)



Source: *European Social Survey (ESS11), France sample*

This illuminates a central limitation within orthodox models of economic voting. Retrospective accounts articulated by Fiorina are highly effective in explaining periods of incumbent vulnerability, but alone, remain politically homeless until given ideological direction. Economic precarity may substantiate resentment towards incumbent institutions, but individually does not expound why such resentment becomes expressed particularly through exclusionary nationalism - rather than redistributionist left politics, or political disengagement altogether. Reflecting broader supply-side accounts of populist radical right success, grievances unaccompanied are insufficient without parties being capable of structuring them into electorally meaningful cleavages.⁶ The party's distinctive contribution lies in converting diffuse socioeconomic frustration into a culturally intelligible narrative reorganised, and centred upon elite betrayal and social fragmentation.

This also does not imply that grievances economically are analytically irrelevant in this case study, but it is on the contrary. Financial instability may intensify perceptions of cultural threat and institutional abandonment, making the relationship between economic and cultural explanations less separable in practice than theoretical models may imply. Economic precarity can heighten competition and social decline, reinforcing conditions under which exclusionary and nativist narratives become politically persuasive. The discrepancy between economic and

⁶ Art, David(2011). *Inside the Radical Right: The Development of Anti-Immigrant Parties in Western Europe*. Cambridge University Press

cultural voting should thereby be understood as an interaction through which financial hardship is interpreted through symbolic and identity-based frameworks.

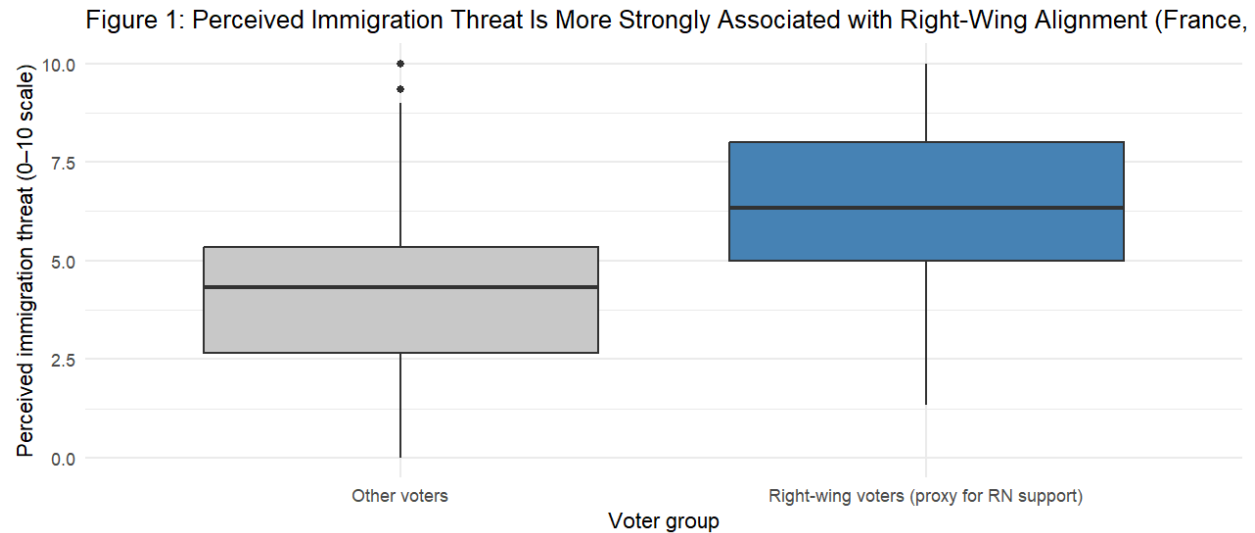
At the core, the question then consequently shifts from whether grievances exist, to: how do these grievances acquire political direction? Through this shift, we place the threat of immigration at the heart of contemporary explanations of RN support.

Immigration concerns

Immigration inhabits a quintessentially unique position through explanations of contemporary populist radical right voting; it functions much more than a policy issue, but orchestrates itself as a symbolic framework through which broader anxieties adjacent to nationhood, belonging, and political authority are politically organised. Through the French case, support for the RN must not be adequately reduced to simplistic claims of prejudice or 'racism' alone, despite the centrality of exclusionary politics to the party's appeal. Explanations like these are analytically insufficient; in turn they fail to truly explain why immigration becomes electorally salient primarily, and moreover why support for the RN has transcended beyond traditionally extremist communities and why it structures political behaviour more strongly in some contexts rather than others. The rise of the RN is more clearly elucidated through the concept of nativism identified by Mudde(2007) as the defining ideological core of the populist radical right, in which the state is imagined as belonging predominantly to a culturally homogenous native community threatened by external "outsiders" and internally detached elites.⁷ This allows immigration to become constructed as evidence of a much broader crisis of sovereignty, cultural continuity and national decline. Shown in Figure 1, perceived immigration threat is substantially more concentrated amongst right-wing respondents than amongst the wider electorate, although most importantly - the distributions continue to overlap to a notable degree. This distinction is then analytically significant as it encapsulates that anti-immigration attitudes are not exclusive to RN-aligned voters, nor does perceived immigration threat mechanically translate into support for the populist radical right.

Figure 1: Perceived Immigration Threat Is More Strongly Associated with Right-Wing Alignment (France, ESS2024)

⁷ Mudde, Cas (2007), *Populist Radical Right Parties in Europe*. Cambridge, Cambridge University Press



*Immigration threat index constructed from recoded ESS variables. Variables measure perceptions of immigration's effects on the economy, culture and social life. **Source:** European Social Survey (ESS11), France Sample*

Instead of functioning as an absolute predictor of vote choice, immigration-related threat perceptions operate probabilistically which increases the likelihood of right-wing alignment without fully determining it. Such a pattern is entirely consistent with broader models of voting behaviour in which attitudes structure electoral tendencies, while remaining mediated by wider ideological and partisan frameworks.

Operationalisation of immigration attitudes is theoretically important; the initial descriptive measures risked obscuring the substantive direction of the relationship due to reverse coding within the ESS immigration variables - measuring whether or not respondents perceived immigration to be beneficial or harmful to the country's economy, culture and overall social life. In order to address this, the variables were further recoded into a composite index of perceived immigration threat to allow itself to become more accurate operationalisation of the concept central to radical right literature. The adjustment methodologically strengthened the explanatory coherence of the findings and brought the empirical analysis into far more closer alignment with the expansive scholarship on populist radical right voting.

The regression results demonstrated by Table 1 help reinforce this. Across all model specifications, perceived immigration threat stands the strongest and most consistent predictor of right-wing alignment. Model 1 exhibits that immigration alone exhibits a highly statistically

significant positive relationship with support for the populist right, pressing,ly, this effect even persists after the introduction of Models 2 and 3.

Table 1: Logistic Regression Predicting Right-Wing Alignment(Proxy for RN Support), France 2024

	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3
(Intercept)	-4.263*** (0.388)	-3.686*** (1.023)	-2.950** (1.141)
imm_threat_index	0.504*** (0.063)	0.513*** (0.070)	0.393*** (0.108)
economy		-0.038 (0.070)	-0.032 (0.071)
education		0.028 (0.044)	0.027 (0.044)
trust		0.050 (0.065)	-0.182 (0.180)
agea		-0.000 (0.009)	0.000 (0.009)
gndr		-0.687** (0.262)	-0.679** (0.262)
imm_threat_index × trust			0.039 (0.028)
Num.Obs.	542	525	525
AIC			
BIC			
Log.Lik.			
RMSE	0.34	0.34	0.34

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

The dependent variable is right-wing alignment(binary proxy for support for the Reassemblent National). Coefficients are log-odds from a logistic regression model. Standard errors are in parentheses. Model 1 shows immigration threat only; Model 2 showcases socioeconomic and demographic controls; Model 3 introduces an interaction between

immigration threat and political trust. Controls include: age, education, income, and economic dissatisfaction. Coefficients reported as log-odds. Statistical significance: $p < .05$, $p < .01$.

Source: *European Social Survey (ESS11), France sample*

The relationship's persistence is theoretically significant, as it further suggests that immigration-related perceptions retain explanatory power independently of extensive socioeconomic malaise. Strikingly, economic dissatisfaction becomes statistically insignificant once immigration attitudes are introduced upon the model - despite widespread economic precarity identified in Figure 2. Thereby, it points to a crux; economic grievances may generate political frustration - but the findings advocate that immigration-related cultural threat plays a markedly more of a role in structuring the ideological direction, through which that frustration is ultimately expressed upon. The significance of this finding prevails the party's success in establishing ownership over the political meaning of immigration itself; RN's distinctive advantage is through its capacity to offer the most politically coherent explanation for why that threat allegedly exists, allowing immigration to be electorally powerful, not just as an issue position - but as a symbolic organising principle interlinking insecurity and identity anxieties into a populist framework. Although the regression findings are theoretically significant, it should be interpreted with caution, as the ideological self-placement as a proxy for RN support simplifies the complexity of electoral behaviour. Cross-sectional ESS data limits stronger causal inference regarding the interaction between immigration attitudes and political trust over time, therefore the evidence presented attitudinal association rather than deterministic causal relationships.

Moreover, these findings are utmost consistent with broader literature on radical right voting. We can see this from Rydgren's(2004) argument, in which Rydgren points to the notion that the electoral success of contemporary far-right parties rests upon a 'new winning formula': whereby ethnonationalist appeals are then fused with populist anti-elitism, and reframed through narratives of cultural incompatibility rather than overt biological racism.⁸ This connects to the French case, it showcases as particularly relevant where the RN had undergone a long-term process of "de-demonisation" under Le Pen, softening explicitly extremist rhetoric whilst preserving the underlying logic of exclusionary nationalism.⁹ Immigration becomes politically

⁸ Rydgren, J. (2004), 'Explaining the Emergence of Radical Right-Wing Populist Parties: The Case of Denmark', *West European Politics*, 27(3), pp. 474–502.

⁹ How Le Pen's far-right party went from 'de-demonisation' to 'normalisation' - France 24. Accessed: (08/05/26)
<https://www.france24.com/en/france/20220804-how-le-pen-s-far-right-party-went-from-de-demonisation-to-normalisation>

effective, centrally as the RN has successfully established ownership over the issue and embedded it into an extensive narrative interlinking immigration to insecurity, social fragmentation, and elite betrayal. Therefore, immigration is made to operate in this sense not only as a positional issue, but as a symbolic organising device which otherwise diffuse anxieties are rendered politically coherent.

Populism, Distrust and the Political Organisation of Grievance

RN's success in 2024 stems less from the existence of economic malaise and immigration concerns, but from its superior capacity to politically organise them into a coherent moral narrative of national betrayal. Economic insecurity, cultural threat and institutional distrust do not automatically cohere into populist radical right itself, when left independently fragmented, such grievances linger politically unstable and ideologically indeterminate. RN achieves a transformation of diffuse social anxieties into a unified interpretive framework through which otherwise disconnected experiences of precarities, cultural displacement and political alienation become experienced as symptoms of the same perceived crisis of national betrayal.

Populism in this case, then operates as consequential rather than anti-elite rhetoric alone.

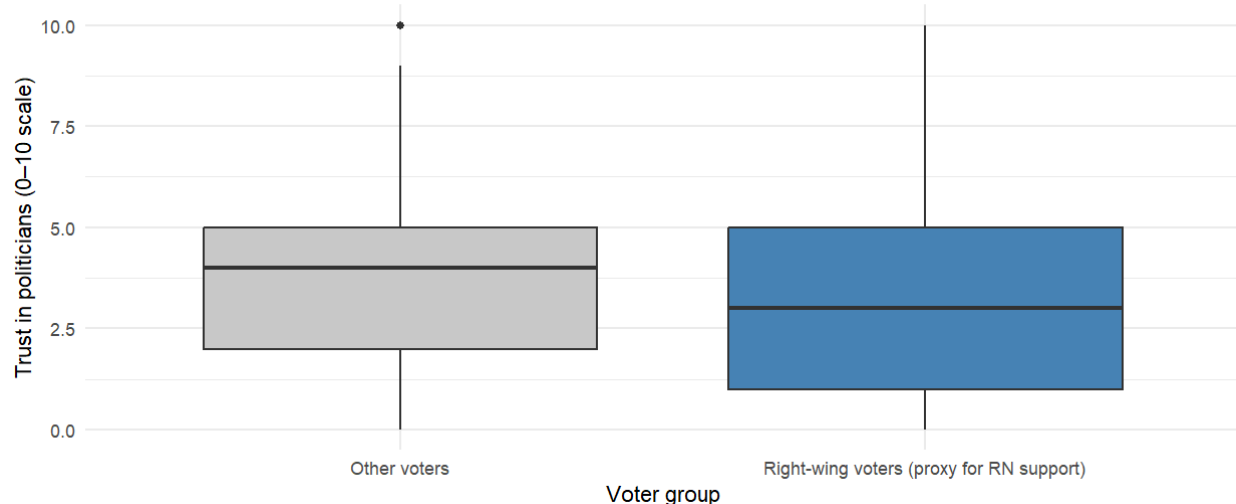
Mudde's(2004) conception of populism as a moral antagonist between the "pure people" against the "corrupt elite", orchestrates politics itself as a struggle over legitimacy and belonging of the nation.¹⁰ Distrust therefore destabilises the credibility of intermediary institutions traditionally responsible for organising democratic representation; once institutional legitimacy weakens, political grievances no longer require technocratic solutions, so much as emotionally convincing explanations capable of restoring moral coherence to social change. This interplay reflects partisan alignment and weakening institutional legitimacy within European democracies, benefiting outsider parties adept in reconstructing conflict through exclusionary narratives.(Kriesi et al., 2008; Rydgen, 2005)¹¹

Figure 3: Political Distrust is More Strongly Associated with Right-Wing Alignment(France, ESS 2024)

¹⁰ Mudde, Cas(2004), *The Populist Zeitgeist*, Government & Opposition, Cambridge University Press, 39(4) pg.541-563

¹¹ Kriesi, H., Grande, E., Lachat, R., Dolezal., M., Bornschier, S., and Frey, T.(2008) *West European Politics in the Age of Globalisation.* , Cambridge University Press; Rydgren, J., (2005), '*Is extreme right-wing populism contagious? Explaining the new emergence of a new party family*', *European Journal of Political Research*, 44(3), pg. 413-417

Figure 3: Political Distrust Is More Strongly Associated with Right-Wing Alignment (France, ESS 2024)



*Political distrust measured using the ESS trust-in-politicians variable (0-10 scale). **Source:** European Social Survey(ESS Round 11), France sample.*

Figure 3 indicates that RN-aligned respondents exhibit systematically lower levels of trust in politicians than the broader electorate. The significance of distrust within populist politics lies less in its statistical presence itself than in what distrust permits politically; by destabilising the authority of institutions traditionally responsible for mediating social conflict and organising democratic representation, the symptoms of economic decline, cultural change and insecurity cease to appear as isolated policy challenges - instead becoming increasingly interpretable as interdependent of elite abandonment and national deterioration.

By transforming fragmented experiences of anxiety into a morally coherent account of social reality, RN's political strength is spotlighted. Through weaving together cultural dislocation, immigration, perceived insecurity into a unified narrative into which structural transformations are rendered emotionally intelligible. What populism then offers is not just opposition, but an interpretive clarity: a simplified explanation identifying who has betrayed the nation, who then belongs to the authentic political community, and lastly, who must ultimately be held responsible for collective decline?

The success of the RN sheds a light onto the deeper crisis of democratic representation extending beyond conventional issue voting alone. Populist radical right voting builds a power base, because it succeeds in politically narrating grievances. Economic discontent breeds frustration; immigration structures cultural threat; distrust then equips the sword of moral antagonism of the alienated elite, and the perception that the nation itself has been

fundamentally betrayed. Populism does not merely operate as an electoral strategy, but the eventual procedure through which diffuse social insecurities are then reorganised into a coherent worldview around exclusionary belonging and anti-elite resentment.

Conclusion

Uncovering the rise of the RN in 2024 exposes a transformation in contemporary democratic politics, wherein political distrust and economic, cultural anxieties cease to function solitarily - instead converging in the analytical distinction between economic and cultural explanations becoming increasingly unstable. Immigration-related threat perceptions materialised as the strongest predictor of right-wing alignment in the analysis, however the findings also equally unveiled the limitations of monocausal explanations of populist voting. Economic dissatisfaction was widespread across the electorate; but even so materially insecure voters did not move uniformly towards the populist radical right, likewise with anti-immigration attitudes that were not exclusive to RN-aligned respondents. The crux is how such grievances become interpreted, organised and ideologically directed.

RN's electoral advantage lies not in articulating grievances more effectively than its competitors, but through transforming fragmented forms of insecurity. Succeeding in providing a coherent framework; rearranging shattered illusions of political institutions, economic decline and cultural fragmentation into a unifying myth of national decline, elite treason and exclusionary belonging. Consequently, the French case may suggest that the distinction between "economic" and "cultural" explanations of populist voting may itself be analytically unstable; populist parties actively convert material insecurity into symbolic and identity-based forms of political conflict. Thus, economic insecurity does not disappear within contemporary populist parties, but becomes narratively reconstructed through questions of identity, sovereignty and belonging.

In this respect, RN's rise in 2024 mirrors more than just a temporary surge in support for the populist radical right alone. It highlights a deeper transformation in contemporary European democracy by which electoral conflict is continuously organised around competing struggles over legitimacy, representation, and the authority to define who legitimately belongs to the nation itself. Contemporary populism's power resides in not merely just expressing dissatisfaction, but in politically narrating social reality itself.

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